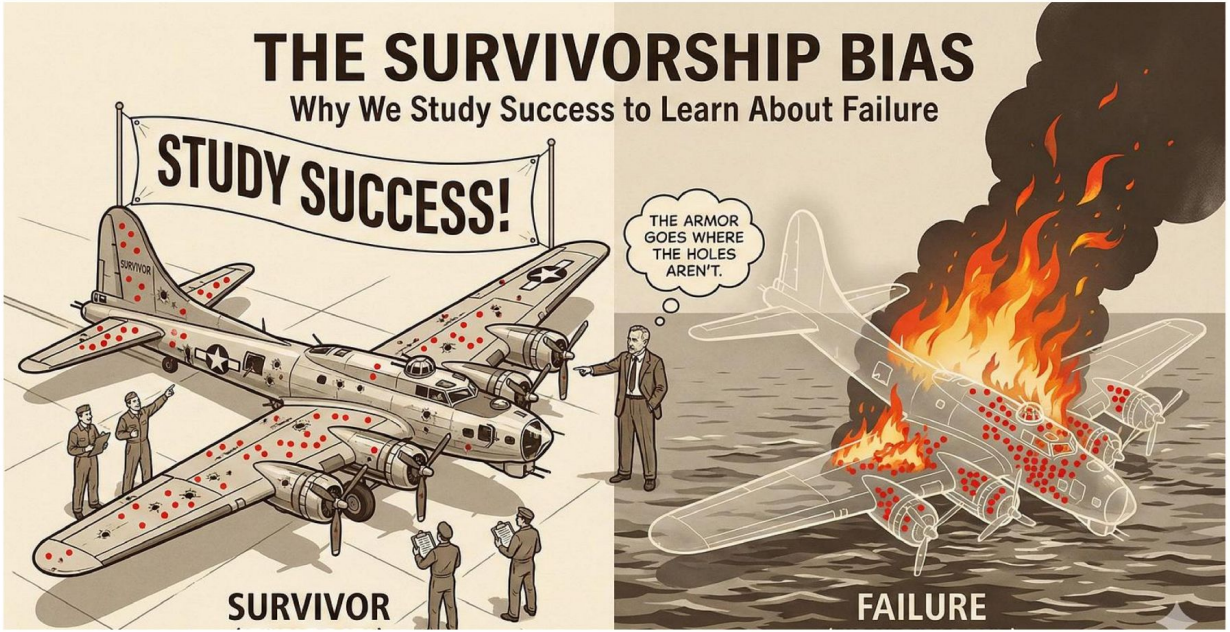
BUILD LIKE A FOUNDER

Measuring What Actually Matters

Your dashboard is lying to you.

> Direct frameworks, insights, Indian case anchors.

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Seat Belts, Smokers, Soldier helmets,

For your dashboard: you only see the users who stayed. The metric that matters is often about the ones who left.

A STORY

The metric that lied to me

> **I checked one number every morning for 6 months. It improved weekly.**
>
> It was completely useless.

— A FOUNDER, REFLECTING BACK

WHAT IT COST ME

THE LESSON

A metric that doesn't change what you do next is entertainment, not insight.

THE COST

Bad decisions, missed signals. Six months on the wrong number.

THE REALISATION

When I finally looked at what mattered, the gap between signal and vanity was shocking.

FRAMEWORK 1

Three types of metrics.

LAYER 1

Leading

Predicts tomorrow's outcome. Changes when you change something this week. Actionable today.

Activation rate
e.g. % of sign-ups reaching aha-moment

LAYER 2

Lagging

Confirms what already happened. Worth checking, but moves 4–12 weeks after the leading layer.

Monthly revenue
lagging by definition — true test is leading

LAYER 3

Vanity

Goes up while the company bleeds. Feels good, changes nothing about what you do Monday morning.

Total sign-ups
a graveyard of "growth" dashboards

FRAMEWORK 1 · IN PRACTICE

Leading vs lagging, by context.

CONTEXT	LEADING	LAGGING
Sales	Number of qualified leads	Revenue
Sales	Sales meetings booked	Deals closed
Sales	Proposal-to-prospect ratio	New customers
SaaS	Product demos completed	ARR / MRR
SaaS	Weekly active users	Annual retention
SaaS	Feature adoption	Customer churn
E-commerce	Add-to-cart rate	Sales / GMV
Marketing	Website traffic	Revenue generated
Marketing	Qualified leads	Customer acquisition
Customer success	Product usage	Renewal rate

CONTEXT	LEADING	LAGGING
Hiring	Qualified candidates in pipeline	Employees hired
Employee performance	Training hours / practice	Sales or productivity outcome
Fitness	Workout frequency	Weight / strength / VO_2 max
Finance	Cash burn	Cash runway
Manufacturing	Preventive maintenance completed	Machine breakdowns
Quality	Defect checks performed	Customer complaints
Startup	Number of customer interviews	Product-market fit / revenue
Startup	Activation rate	Retention
Startup	Repeat usage	LTV

FRAMEWORK 2

The 5-layer metric stack

Read from the outside in. Start with money, end with the engine that keeps it alive.

01	**Business** Is the company durable? Cash, runway, gross margin.	**runway · g-margin · NRR**	RUNWAY MONTHS · GROSS MARGIN % · NET REVENUE RETENTION
02	**Customer** Are the right people buying? Quality beats quantity.	**CAC payback · ICP mix**	CAC PAYBACK · ICP MIX % · FIRST-90-DAY RETENTION
03	**Engagement** Are users getting value, or just hoarding the app?	**weekly active · depth**	WEEKLY ACTIVE USE · DEPTH ACTIONS / SESSION · FEATURE BREADTH
04	**Operational** Is the unit-engine running, or are we paying it to?	**cost · cycle · burn**	SUPPORT COST / USER · FULFILLMENT CYCLE TIME · BURN MULTIPLE
05	**Health** The early-warning layer. Fires before revenue does.	**NPS · retention curve**	NPS · COHORT RETENTION CURVE · POWER-USER SHARE

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FRAMEWORK 3

One number to chase. One to protect.

Every team needs a North Star, and a counter-metric to keep them honest.

NORTH STAR

The one that goes up when the company wins.

Connects what customers love to what the business earns. Leading first, lagging okay, never vanity.

ASK

“If this goes up forever, do we win?”

COUNTER-METRIC

The one that warns when we’re gaming it.

Anytime a team owns a North Star, they will optimise it locally. The counter catches the damage first.

ASK

“What would break if I pushed this hard?”

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FRAMEWORK 3 · WHO DOES WHAT

North Stars in the wild.

COMPANY	NORTH STAR	COUNTER-METRIC
Uber	Completed rides	Cancellation rate / driver earnings
Airbnb	Nights booked	Cancellation rate / host satisfaction
Swiggy / Zomato	Successful orders delivered	Cancellation rate / delivery time
Amazon	Successful purchases	Returns / customer complaints
Netflix	Hours of content meaningfully watched	Churn / customer satisfaction
Spotify	Hours of music listened to	Churn / skips
YouTube	Meaningful watch time	Negative feedback / abandonment
Instagram	Meaningful engagement sessions	User reports / time-to-value
LinkedIn	Meaningful connections or professional interactions	Spam / report rate
WhatsApp	Meaningful conversations	Spam / blocks

COMPANY	NORTH STAR	COUNTER-METRIC
Google Search	Successful searches	Reformulation rate
Google Maps	Successful navigation trips	Wrong-route reports
Duolingo	Lessons completed / learning activity	Learning quality / churn
Canva	Designs created / exported	Failed exports / churn
Slack	Teams actively collaborating	Notification overload / churn
Zoom	Successful meeting minutes	Meeting failures / churn
Notion	Active collaborative workspaces	Workspace abandonment
Razorpay	Successful payment transactions	Payment failure / fraud rate
Lending fintech	Successful loans repaid	Default / NPA rate

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FRAMEWORK 4

Averages lie. Cohorts tell the truth.

Two companies can share a retention average yet have nothing in common.

THE AVERAGE

Mixes dead users with power users



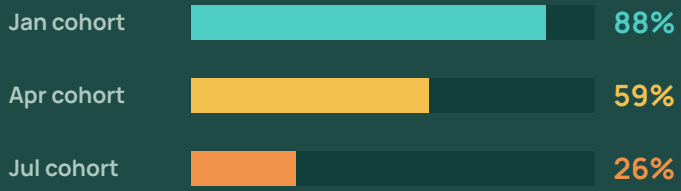
LOOKS LIKE

60% retention

Hides the truth: 20% power users carry the metric, 80% churn by week 4.

THE COHORT VIEW

Three cohorts, three honest stories



Averaging them hides that the product got worse. The cohort view fires the alarm.

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COHORT ANATOMY

% of each cohort still active, week by week.

COHORT	W0	W1	W2	W3	W4	W6	W8	W12
APR	100	72	64	58	52	48	45	42
MAY	100	58	46	41	38	36	35	33
JUN	100	40	29	26	24	22	21	19
JUL	100	52	45	43	42	41	40	40

% OF COHORT ACTIVE — NUMBERS ILLUSTRATIVE

READ THE BEND

Don't follow the average across cohorts. Find the week each row bends — that is where retention is decided.

READ THE ALARM

When a row collapses early, the next 30 days are the company's to-do list.

Illustrative only. Pull your own equivalent. The columns you choose to add decide what questions you can ask.

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CASE STUDIES · QUICK READS

Same company. Better number.

Boat

Followers & reach → **Revenue per SKU × repeat**

Lifestyle brand discipleship > influencer follower count.

Freshworks

Total customer logos → **ARR & Net Retention**

SMB logos were a vanity stack; the public-market operator watched ARR.

Dream11

App installs → **Match-engagement cohort**

How many came back for the next match, regardless of marketing.

Zerodha

Account openings → **Active traders × P&L per trader**

Sign-ups are free; value lives in who actually trades and keeps capital.

FRAMEWORK 5

Inputs you push. Outputs you only earn.

Most founders worship outputs. The discipline is to invest in inputs - and watch outputs to confirm.

YOU PUSH

Inputs.

DIRECT LEVERS YOU CAN MOVE THIS WEEK

Outreach cadence
Calls shipped, demos booked, replies back.

Shipping velocity
Experiments shipped, bugs fixed, features in beta.

Support quality
First-response, resolution time, escalation rate.

YOU MEASURE

Outputs.

CHANGES THAT HAPPEN 4–12 WEEKS LATER

Revenue
Compresses both wins and noise — check before celebrating.

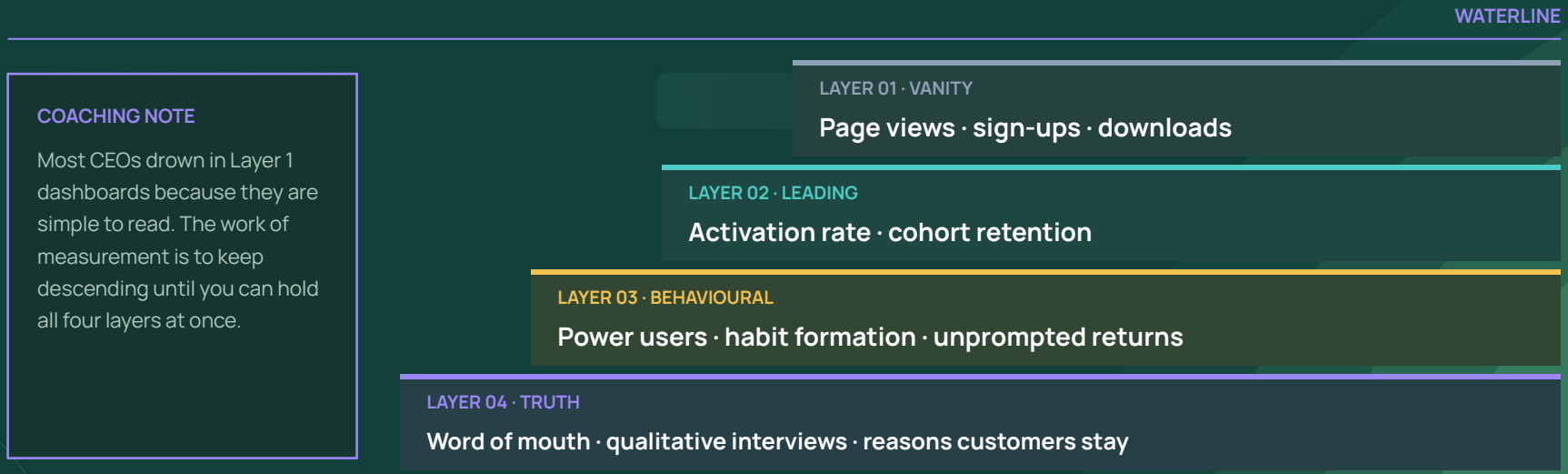
Cohort retention
Outputs lag inputs — reveal whether the inputs worked.

NPS, brand affinity
Outputs compound. Months of careless inputs surface here.

FRAMEWORK 6

Above water. Below water.

The number on your dashboard is the tip. The company lives underneath.



COACHING NOTE

Most CEOs drown in Layer 1 dashboards because they are simple to read. The work of measurement is to keep descending until you can hold all four layers at once.

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FRAMEWORK 7

Goodhart's Law

> *When a measure becomes a target, it stops being a good measure.*

CASE 1

Wells Fargo / SBI fake accounts scandal

Staff were measured on accounts opened. The number went up - by opening accounts customers never asked for.

CASE 2

The Cobra Effect (colonial India)

The story goes: a bounty on dead cobras led people to breed cobras for the reward. The target grew; the problem did too.

REMEMBER you get what you pay for, not what you want.

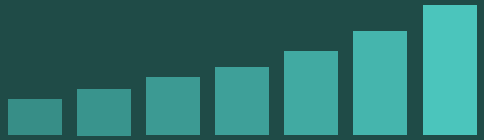
SAMPLE DASHBOARD · EARLY-STAGE SAAS

SAMPLE / TEMPLATE

Five cards on a wall. One that actually moves the team.

HERO · NET REVENUE RETENTION

112%



8-QUARTER TREND

WHY THIS ONE

A payments company can grow TPV while merchants quietly leave. NRR catches the bleed early.

CAC PAYBACK

8.4mo

Under 12 months indicates healthy unit economics at this stage.

WEEKLY ACTIVE WORKSPACES

38%

Of paid accounts touched the product in the last 7 days.

Illustrative only. Sub in your own numbers. Numbers shown are not real metrics of any company.

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SAMPLE DASHBOARD · CONSUMER APP

SAMPLE / TEMPLATE

Account for the “open it once and leave” user.

HERO · DAILY STICKINESS

27%

DAU ÷ MAU

Share of monthly users opening the app today. Below 20% means the app is becoming disposable.

ACTIVATION RATE

43%

Sign-ups hitting the “aha” moment.

D7 RETENTION

21%

Of new users back on day 7.

SESSIONS / WAU

8.2

Frequency among weekly actives.

POWER-USER SHARE

8%

Top-decile weekly users.

LAST 4 WEEKS · LEADING INDICATORS MOVEMENT

Activation



D7 retention



Stickiness



Illustrative only. Replace with your own numbers; treat thresholds as conversation starters, not truths.

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SAMPLE DASHBOARD · MARKETPLACE

SAMPLE / TEMPLATE

Two sides that lie to each other. Watch them both.

MONTHLY TRANSACTING USERS **248k**

SUPPLY SIDE

Who can be booked.

FILL RATE

82%

% of capacity booked.

EARNINGS / PROVIDER

₹19k

Median weekly. The real retention lever.

DEMAND SIDE

Who is asking.

REPEAT RATE

38%

% buyers re-booking in 30 days.

TAKE RATE

18%

% commission, post-discounts.

SHARED HEALTH

ESCALATIONS

4.2%

COHORT SUPPLY STAY · D60 SUPPLY RETENTION

71%

SUPPORT CYCLE · FIRST-RESPONSE TIME

11 min

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SAMPLE DASHBOARD · D2C COMMERCE

SAMPLE / TEMPLATE

Margins show up months after the campaigns do.

HERO · REPEAT ORDER RATE

34%

BUYERS WHO BUY TWICE

GROSS MARGIN

58%

Net of returns. Lagging, but the only metric that says you are a business.

BLENDED CAC

₹620

Last-30-days, all channels. Pair with AOV before celebrating.

REPEAT ORDER RATE BY WEEK · 8 WEEKS

Bars rise = the campaign that ran two weeks ago is working. Bars fall = audience saturated or creative tired.



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OPERATING PRACTICE

When a metric lies. Four small diagnostics.

Read what the dashboard says, then read what your gut says. Pick the diagnostic that matches.

SYMPTOM · GOING UP

**Number climbs.
Company is bleeding.**

VERDICT

Probably vanity. Strip from the dashboard on Friday, sleep on it.

SYMPTOM · HOVERING

**No movement, no story.
What changed?**

VERDICT

Cohorts first. Segment, then ask which slice still has a curve.

SYMPTOM · LAGGING LATE

**Looked fine, then broke.
Where was the warning?**

VERDICT

You were watching the lagging. Promote the leading version next quarter.

SYMPTOM · PLATEAU

**Ceiling hit. Cohort flat.
Is this the TAM?**

VERDICT

Possibly the metric is done. Retire it; pick one with a different ceiling.

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CLOSING · MODULE 6

Take it home.

Five numbers you actually watch.
A ritual on Monday. Trust the rest less.

01

You measure for decisions

Pick actions, not impressions. A metric without a Monday move is decoration.

02

You own what you measure

One human, one North Star, one counter. Without an owner, the number drifts unseen.

03

Discipline compounds

Cadence + cohorts + counter-metrics — the boring work that wins quietly.

YOUR FIVE NUMBERS

A stack you can name

1. Business — is it durable?
2. Customer — are they right?
3. Engagement — are they deep?
4. Operational — is the engine sound?
5. Health — what fires early?